

Reading Responses

Programming Design Systems:

“For a field rooted in the fine arts, this has been a difficult transition. Many graphic design schools have resorted to teaching a waterfall philosophy where students are positioned to think of themselves as creatives who come up with ideas for others to build.:

- I believe that this is quote is a bit controversial. While I was studying graphic design as part of my associate's degree I was taught not only about the craft but theory as well. We started with the history of graphic design from print to web. So I believe is unfair to say that many teach a “waterfall philosophy”.

“If graphic designers do not become fluent in this new digital reality, they will become irrelevant”.

- I fully agree with this statement. There are still people from my graduating class who got their BA in Design and are still reluctant to become fluent in digital prototyping tools such as Figma. I believe that it's not just about learning these tools but learning about a design process through these tools

“Throwing a design over the wall for production is a bad legacy of the printed page, and there is no reason for the design process to end with the birth of a product”.

- I feel that this statement is the result of unfortunate common practice in today's design industry. So far in my early career, I have had experience in creating designs simply just to throw into production and not really having to maintain them over time as the PMs shift to the next big thing. I disagree with this approach but it is hard to disagree when you are entry-level within an organization.

What do Prototypes Prototype?:

“Prototypes provide the means for examining design problems and evaluating solutions. Selecting the focus of a prototype is the art of identifying the most important open design questions.”

- I completely agree with this point. During my work experience in product design, I have focused on prototyping to ensure we addressed users' needs effectively and tested them through research. By addressing these critical questions early, I was able to ensure that the prototype served as a targeted tool for iteration rather than an overwhelming, unfocused representation.

“Current ways of talking about prototypes tend to focus on attributes of the prototype itself... Such characterizations can be misleading because the capabilities and possible uses of tools are often misunderstood.”

- I've noticed this firsthand when using tools like Figma, people often equate its high-fidelity outputs with being final designs. It's essential to shift the conversation toward the prototype's intent, such as validating user flows or testing interaction models, rather than getting distracted by the visuals.

"Prototypes are not necessarily self-explanatory: looks can be deceiving. Clarifying what aspects of a prototype correspond to the eventual artifact—and what don't—is a key part of successful prototyping."

- This quote is very important. When presenting prototypes to stakeholders, I make it a point to clarify their purpose, whether it's exploring functionality or experimenting with visual direction. For example, when prototyping navigation updates, I emphasized that the focus was on layout discoverability rather than final aesthetics, ensuring that feedback stayed on track.